web API controllers, so `ControllerBase` is the better option.

In listing 20.2 you can see that the action method, `Index`, returns a list of strings directly from the action method. When you return data from an action like this, you're providing the API model for the request. The client will receive this data. It's formatted into an appropriate response, a JSON representation of the list in the case of figure 20.2, and sent back to the browser with a `200 OK` status code.

TIP Web API controllers format data as JSON by default. You'll see how to format the returned data in other ways in section 20.6. Minimal API endpoints that return data directly (rather than via an `IResult`) will format data only as JSON; there are no other options.

The URL at which a web API controller action is exposed is handled in the same way as for traditional MVC controllers and Razor Pages: using routing. The `[HttpGet("fruit")]` attribute applied to the `Index` method indicates that the method should use the route template `"fruit"` and should respond to HTTP `GET` requests. You'll learn more about attribute routing in section 20.4, but it's similar to the minimal API routing that you're already familiar with.

In listing 20.2 data is returned directly from the action method, but you don't *have* to do that. You're free to return an `IActionResult` instead, and often this is required. Depending on the desired behavior of your API, you sometimes want to return data, and other times you may want to return a raw HTTP status code, indicating whether the request was successful. For example, if an API call is made requesting details of a product that does not exist, you might want to return a `404 Not Found` status code.